

PestPatrol

Pest Patrol seemed to be very promising, based on the information on their Web site. The site has very detailed information on all the types of spyware. The program itself claims to block several thousand known spyware objects. When we first ran PestPatrol, it scanned for a couple of minutes and found no spyware objects. Surprised by the results, we started from scratch. This time the scan was painfully slow, but it found over 500 pests. The information is presented in a table with a fair amount of information—the name of the pest, category it belongs to, a short description of what it does, the level of risk it poses, and whether PestPatrol has confirmed that it is actually the spyware that it is suspected to be.

Unfortunately, a lot of the results were just suspected pests and not confirmed as spyware. The interface is a little awkward, and the



Spyware objects found in Pest Patrol

program's options are extensive but hard to access. Options let you decide where to scan, what types of pests to scan for, what folders should be excluded, etc. Automatic scanning at system startup is available, but not enabled by default. Pest patrol has real-time memory monitoring with a system

tray icon. From there the program can also update itself when you're online. Yet it's hard to recommend this commercial tool over the better free tools tested.

Price: \$ 39.95 ■ Web site: www.pestpatrol.com ■ Grade: B-

Ad-Aware

Ad-Aware is the most well known of the tools we tested. Now in its sixth incarnation, Ad-Aware remains free, but advanced features such as real-time protection are only available in the commercial versions, namely Ad-Aware Plus and Professional. After installing and running the program a starting screen gives you an overview of the current system status. From there you can click Start, and simply follow the instructions to begin a scan.



The first screen gives plenty of details at a glance

Ad-Aware does a very thorough job of detecting and removing spyware. It also impressed us with its speed. The detection process took a just over a minute, with the default options, and the cleaning took under 10 seconds. The results are presented in a table but the

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Anti-virus tools make use of advanced techniques to detect possible viruses—files that show 'virus like' behaviour. Anti-spyware tools do not normally implement such techniques, because of the high rate of false alarms that would be generated, and useful files maybe deleted. They rely heavily on their database of known spyware. This makes it essential for you to keep the software up to date.

Becoming proactive

Putting in a little effort will ensure you don't get spyware on your PC in the first place. You should find out before you install software if it contains spyware. A good way to do this is to visit www.spychecker.com and enter the name of the software in the search box. The results tell you what type of spyware (if any) it contains. Then its up to you to decide if you want to use it or not.

information provided here is limited—you have to right-click each item, and select 'Item Details' for additional information, and this information wasn't much either. Ad-Aware missed a few objects that the other tools caught, but did a thorough job overall. You can scan within archives, but that would increase the time taken. The program can start with Windows, and has automated scanning features. Ad-Aware remains a solid and reliable choice for clearing out spyware.

Price: Free ■ Web site: www.lavasoftusa.com ■ Grade: B+

X-Cleaner

X-Cleaner is a privacy tool that does a lot more than clear spyware. This tool is very small in size but has a whole host of features. It removes several types of spyware, shreds (permanently deletes) files, manages your startup programs, generates complex passwords, and updates itself automatically. Click the Start Cleaning button and it starts scanning for known spyware, and then



X-Cleaner prompts an action for each object it finds—one at a time

presents the option to clean one spyware object at a time. The program was intelligent enough to find an uninstaller for the spyware bundled with KaZaA, and started the uninstall process for us. This is a lot better than just blindly deleting all the spyware objects found. This is time consuming however, and will

require some patience. Disappointingly, X-Cleaner did not detect a lot of our test spyware.

Price: \$ 39.95 ■ Web site: www.xblock.com ■ Grade: B

Spy Sweeper

Webroot Spy Sweeper is a shareware spyware removal software. The common features of the program are available for use free of cost. It is capable of identifying and removing Adware, cookies, data-mining programs and Trojans.

The program is installed in less than 30 seconds, and an option is given to update the spyware definitions. The scan time on the test bed took 2 minutes, and 20 seconds. The program tracked 9 spyware agents



The smartest looking interface of the bunch